

Nielsen Norman Group **Heuristic Evaluation Workbook**

Use this workbook to conduct your own heuristic evaluation.

For each of Jakob's 10 Usability Heuristics, look for specific places where the interface fails to adhere to the guideline. Write your recommendations for how to fix those usability issues.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

1

Visibility of System Status

The design should always keep users informed about what is going on, through appropriate feedback within a reasonable amount of time.

- Does the design clearly communicate its state?
- Is feedback presented quickly after user actions?

Issues

- The system responds to user actions, but important information like navigation and text is visually pushed to corners due to strong background imagery.
- User attention is drawn more to visuals than to system feedback or content.

Recommendations

Improve visual hierarchy so key information and navigation are clearly visible and immediately noticeable after user actions.

2

Match Between System and the Real World

The design should speak the users' language. Use words, phrases, and concepts familiar to the user, rather than internal jargon. Follow real-world conventions, making information appear in a natural and logical order.

- Will user be familiar with the terminology used in the design?
- Do the design's controls follow real-world conventions?

Issues

- Artistic visuals dominate the interface, which may confuse users looking for basic information like navigation or links.
- Text-heavy content placement does not follow a natural reading flow.

Recommendations

Present information in a more natural and logical layout while maintaining the artistic theme.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

3

User Control and Freedom

Users often perform actions by mistake. They need a clearly marked "emergency exit" to leave the unwanted action without having to go through an extended process.

- Does the design allow users to go back a step in the process?
- Are exit links easily discoverable?
- Can users easily cancel an action?
- Is *Undo* and *Redo* supported?

Issues

- Animations may distract users during browsing.

Recommendations

The provided option to stop animations is effective and should remain clearly visible to allow users control over their experience.

4

Consistency and Standards

Users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing. Follow platform and industry conventions.

- Does the design follow industry conventions?
- Are visual treatments used consistently throughout the design?

Issues

- Links and normal text look similar, making it difficult for users to identify clickable elements.
- Menu buttons lack consistent visual styling (shape, spacing).

Recommendations

Use consistent visual treatments for links, buttons, and text across the site to align with standard web conventions.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

5

Error Prevention

Good error messages are important, but the best designs carefully prevent problems from occurring in the first place. Either eliminate error-prone conditions, or check for them and present users with a confirmation option before they commit to the action.

- Does the design prevent slips by using helpful constraints?
- Does the design warn users before they perform risky actions?

Issues

Closely placed menu items without sufficient spacing increase the chance of mis clicks.

Recommendations

Increase spacing and add clear button boundaries to reduce accidental clicks.

6

Recognition Rather Than Recall

Minimize the user's memory load by making elements, actions, and options visible. The user should not have to remember information from one part of the interface to another. Information required to use the design (e.g. field labels or menu items) should be visible or easily retrievable when needed.

- Does the design keep important information visible, so that users do not have to memorize it?
- Does the design offer help in-context?

Issues

Users must visually search and remember where navigation and links are located due to low contrast and unclear hierarchy.

Recommendations

Make navigation elements, links, and important actions clearly visible so users do not need to recall their locations.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

7

Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Shortcuts — hidden from novice users — may speed up the interaction for the expert user such that the design can cater to both inexperienced and experienced users. Allow users to tailor frequent actions.

- Does the design provide accelerators like keyboard shortcuts and touch gestures?
- Is content and functionality personalized or customized for individual users?

Issues

The website allows interaction but may slow down efficient browsing due to heavy visuals and animations.

Recommendations

Maintain animations for creative appeal while ensuring quick access to frequently used content.

8

Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Interfaces should not contain information that is irrelevant or rarely needed. Every extra unit of information in an interface competes with the relevant units of information and diminishes their relative visibility.

- Is the visual design and content focused on the essentials?
- Have all distracting, unnecessary elements been removed?

Issues

- Background images dominate the interface, competing with essential content and reducing readability.
- Highly contrasting text boxes strain the user's eyes.

Recommendations

Reduce visual dominance of background images and blend text containers more smoothly with the layout to improve focus on content.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

9

Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors

Error messages should be expressed in plain language (no error codes), precisely indicate the problem, and constructively suggest a solution.

- Does the design use traditional error message visuals, like bold, red text?
- Does the design offer a solution that solves the error immediately?

Issues

Users may misinterpret plain text as clickable links due to lack of visual distinction.

Recommendations

Clearly differentiate hyperlinks using color, underline, or hover effects to avoid confusion.

10

Help and Documentation

It's best if the system doesn't need any additional explanation. However, it may be necessary to provide documentation to help users understand how to complete their tasks.

- Is help documentation easy to search?
- Is help provided in context right at the moment when the user requires it?

Issues

No major issues observed.

Recommendations

The availability of separate logins for visitors and Yale students/faculty is clear and helpful; continue providing clear, role-based guidance.